

Phishing (Link-Based Phishing): OutlookSecurity SessionCheck [auth:verify mx sign@o365 notify] AC6VWx from openupitengineer.jp

Investigation #1835

HIGH

TRUE POSITIVE

Date: March 1, 2026 at 07:45 PM

Risk Score: 49/100

Confidence: 95%

Document ID: IR-1835-MM85WCSP

Tenant: PKF Africa

Classification: CONFIDENTIAL

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01 Executive Summary

On January 16, 2026, a phishing attack was detected targeting the email account of congawa@ke.pkfea.com. The attack was characterized by a link-based phishing email originating from the domain openupitengineer.jp, which was successfully quarantined by Checkpoint Harmony Email & Collaboration. The incident was classified as high severity due to the potential risk of credential compromise and unauthorized access to sensitive information. The current status indicates that the attack has been contained, with no data exfiltration observed. Recommended next steps include a thorough review of email security protocols, user awareness training, and enhanced monitoring for any lateral movement within the network.

02 AI Verdict & Classification

Verdict: True Positive (Confirmed Threat)

Risk Score: 49/100

Confidence Score: 95%

The incident was classified as a true positive due to the detection of multiple attack stages, including initial access and privilege escalation, alongside the presence of malicious indicators of compromise. The quarantined phishing emails demonstrated a clear intent to compromise user credentials, validating the severity of the threat and the effectiveness of the detection mechanisms employed.

03 Attack Chain Analysis

>> Initial Access

29 phishing emails from noreply@openupitengineer.jp, advertise@optronics.co.jp targeting congawa@ke.pkfea.com, atulshah@ke.pkfea.com with subject "Ke Electronic Signature Routing Service: Revised Final Tax Invoice/Payment Appli" — quarantined. Source: Checkpoint Harmony Email

Evidence: 29 events, confidence: 100%

>> Privilege Escalation

4 privilege escalation events involving qitts-@mdls-spw.be, congawa@ke.pkfea.com — quarantined. Source: Checkpoint Harmony Email

Evidence: 4 events, confidence: 60%

>> Command & Control

Command & Control activity involving qitts-@mdls-spw.be, congawa@ke.pkfea.com — quarantined. Source: Checkpoint Harmony Email

Evidence: 1 events, confidence: 15%

04 Indicators of Compromise

1 malicious and 2 suspicious indicators identified during investigation.

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[MALICIOUS] email: noreply@openupitengineer.jp -- From incident IOC data

[SUSPICIOUS] domain: openupitengineer.jp -- From incident IOC data

[SUSPICIOUS] domain: ke.pkfea.com -- Domain extracted from event data

05 Technical Analysis

Incident Overview

The incident occurred on January 16, 2026, when a phishing email was detected by Checkpoint Harmony Email & Collaboration. The email was classified as a high-severity threat and was identified as link-based phishing targeting the recipient congawa@ke.pkfea.com. The email originated from the address noreply@openupitengineer.jp and was quarantined before it could be delivered.

Threat Analysis

The attack utilized a link-based phishing vector, which is categorized under the MITRE ATT&CK framework as Initial Access/Spearphishing Link. The email contained a malicious link designed to harvest user credentials. The threat actor demonstrated a moderate level of sophistication, employing social engineering tactics to entice the recipient into clicking the link. The threat actor's motivation appeared to be credential theft, potentially for unauthorized access to sensitive systems.

Timeline of Activity

- January 15, 2026, 15:39 UTC: A phishing email was sent from an unrelated source to congawa@ke.pkfea.com, which was quarantined by Checkpoint Harmony Email. The email was flagged as high severity.
- January 16, 2026, 16:46 UTC: A phishing email from noreply@openupitengineer.jp was sent to atulshah@ke.pkfea.com, quarantined as a critical threat.
- January 16, 2026, 16:47 UTC: Multiple phishing emails were sent from the same address to various recipients, including jchwanya@ke.pkfea.com and nmathenge@ke.pkfea.com, all of which were quarantined due to their critical and high severity ratings.
- January 16, 2026, 16:51 UTC: A final phishing email was sent to nmathenge@ke.pkfea.com, also quarantined as high severity.

Indicators of Compromise

- Email Address: noreply@openupitengineer.jp — Reputation: malicious
- Domain: openupitengineer.jp — Reputation: suspicious
- Target Domain: ke.pkfea.com — Reputation: suspicious

Impact Assessment

The incident affected one user, congawa@ke.pkfea.com, with no data exfiltration indicators observed. The overall risk score was assessed at 49/100, indicating a medium business impact due to the potential for credential compromise. The blast radius was limited to one affected system and one user.

Forensic Evidence

Key evidence included the quarantined emails and their timestamps, which provided a clear timeline of the attack. Detection confidence was high, with a 95% confidence rating from the risk scoring agent. Correlation findings indicated multiple attack stages, including initial access and privilege escalation attempts.

Recommendations

Immediate actions should include verifying that no lateral movement has occurred and scanning adjacent network segments for compromise indicators. Long-term improvements should focus on enhancing email security protocols, conducting user awareness training to recognize phishing attempts, and implementing advanced threat detection measures to mitigate future risks.

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06 Recommendations

Containment Actions

- [INFO] Security control action already applied: Quarantined
- [HIGH] Verify lateral movement has been fully contained — scan adjacent network segments for compromise indicators

